killings, particularly in Naran of Shiites, had shocked many in the high echelon of the security establishment. They used army uniforms to stop buses, entered them and after confirming their identities through National Identity Cards as Shiites, they shot the passengers dead. Eye witnesses and those who were not killed (Sunni people) stated that the militants were using satellite telephones to communicate with their higher ups.

In the beginning, the chief of Sipah-e-Sahaba, Maulana Azam Tariq, had disassociated himself from the activities of LeJ on many occasions, but the security operatives and the media believed that they were closely linked and worked in coordination with each other in their operations. For instance, when LeJ terrorist Sheikh Haq Nawaz Jhangvi was due to be hanged in February 2001 for terrorist offences, Maulana Tariq, instead of dissociating himself from the terrorist, led a campaign for the remission of his sentence and also offered diyat (blood money) to Iran. Sheikh Haq Nawaz Jhangvi was 19-years-old when he murdered the Iranian diplomat in Lahore on 19 December 1990. Nawaz was hanged in the Mianwali Central Jail. And it took the courts and the authorities 11 years to give the judgment. During his trial, he was kept at different jails in Punjab.

In addition to having links with SSP, LeJ had active relationships with the Taliban in Afghanistan and Pakistani Taliban (TTP). The members of LeJ had sided with the Taliban ranks in their war against the Northern Alliance. They were part of the Taliban force mainly due to its radical ideology and anti-Shiite stance. Many of its activists also took refuge in Afghanistan during the Taliban rule after killing minority Shiites in Pakistan. The relationship between the Pakistani government and the Taliban dissolved when the latter refused to hand over such elements to Pakistan. The main reason for not handing over them to Pakistan was the ideological synchronisation between the two as well the support LeJ leaders extended to the Taliban in the civil war in Afghanistan. LeJ was also allowed to operate a training camp in Afghanistan just outside Kabul. Although the Taliban refused to admit the claim that they were harbouring these criminals, the presence of the training camp just outside the capital and independent life in Afghanistan made the Pakistani authorities believe that they were backed by the Taliban.

Former Pakistani Interior Minister Moinuddin Haider had visited Kabul and Kandahar in March 2001 and, among other things, discussed